Every person must be able to live in dignity, comfort and peace

16 March 2026

Dear Fellow South African,

This year, we mark three decades since South Africa adopted its democratic Constitution. The Constitution is more than the supreme law of the land; it is a solemn promise that never again should any person be stripped of their humanity and dignity.

Later this week, on 21 March, we will observe Human Rights Day. As we celebrate the rights we have enshrined in our Constitution, we also recall the events at Sharpeville on that day in 1960 when apartheid police opened fire on unarmed protesters, killing 69 people and injuring many more.

As we observe this day, we must reflect on whether we are fulfilling the promise contained in our Constitution.

Of all the values enshrined in our Constitution, one of the most fundamental is the advancement of human dignity. It is the foundation on which the rights to equality, to freedom from discrimination, to education, to health, to a safe environment and others are built. It is the idea that every person possesses an inherent worth that must be respected and protected.

This is a right that must be preserved in all circumstances.

In our Constitution, human dignity is not an abstract ideal, but a concrete right that has meaning in people's daily lives. The right to dignity is operationalised through law, institutions and policies. Our courts continue to assert this right and, where necessary, order government and those in power to take measures to enhance people's dignity.

Protecting a person's right to dignity is not limited to the way people treat each other. It is also about improving the circumstances in which people live. It lies at the heart of the policies and programmes of this government and of the work of many organisations and individuals across society.

Since the adoption of our Constitution, indeed since the advent of our democracy, we have worked to restore the dignity of all South Africans. Millions of South Africans have access to water, electricity, healthcare, education and social support that were denied to them under apartheid.

This work, which we have undertaken together as a society, has enhanced the human dignity of children, who are supported by a child support grant, who have access to early childhood development, who attend fee-free schools, who receive school meals and who will be able to access funding to study at a university or college.

The provision of housing, water and electricity has changed the lives of families across the country, reducing poverty and improving their quality of life.

Human dignity also means that people have to be involved in decisions that affect their lives and that shape their country. That is why it is so important that democratic institutions are built and defended. And that a free media, an independent judiciary and a vibrant civil society reinforce accountability.

We know that our work is far from complete. Poverty, inequality and unemployment remain stubborn obstacles to the full realisation of human dignity for every South African. Closing those gaps is a constitutional imperative that belongs to all of us.

That is why we are working even harder to accelerate the momentum of economic recovery, so that our economy can grow faster, create employment and reduce poverty.

When we mobilise investment to build factories or open mines to create jobs and opportunities for emerging businesses, or when we build new roads and revitalise hospitals, we are working towards a society in which everyone has dignity.

When we lay new pipes to bring water to outlying villages or repair ageing water infrastructure in cities and towns, or when we restore the supply of electricity to communities, we are advancing the right to dignity.

As the global economic outlook becomes increasingly uncertain, we must hold fast to the path we are on. We must sustain our massive investment in infrastructure, continue with far-reaching reforms in energy, water and logistics, overhaul our skills development system and expand support to small businesses.

On Human Rights Day this year, let us rededicate ourselves to the Constitution and to its most cherished principles. Let us resolve in our homes, schools, workplaces and communities to treat every person with the dignity that is their right – and let us never stop working until we have ensured that every person can live in dignity, comfort and peace.

With best regards,

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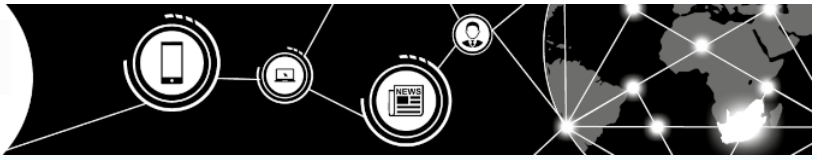

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